



DSP Trainer Selection & Retention Impact Report

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A Structured, Competency-Based Hiring System

PRESENTED TO:

Ascend Day Program

BY:

Priyanka Singh, Khyati Maan,
Nathaniel A. Gordon, Dheeraj
Kannegenti

Table Content

Executive Summary	03
Introduction	04
Organizational Needs & Hiring Challenges	05
Retention Impact & ROI Justification	06
DSP Trainer Competency Model	07
Complete Selection System Overview	08
Structured Behavioral Interview Guide	09-10
Situational Judgement Test (SJT)	11
Teaching/Coaching Demonstration Rubric	12
Weighted Scoring Matrix	13
Realistic Job Preview (RJP)	14
Onboarding Recommendations	14
Implementation Roadmap	15
Conclusion	15

Executive Summary

The Ascend Day Program offers community-based services for adults with developmental disabilities, providing meaningful opportunities for connection, skill development, and increased independence. For adults with developmental disabilities, the Ascend Day Program offers community-based services that offer significant chances for independence, skill development, and connection. Direct Support Professional (DSP) Trainers are central to this mission because they prepare frontline staff to deliver consistent, safe, and compassionate support.

About Our Company

Our team partnered with Ascend to design a more structured, competency-based selection system for the DSP trainer role. The current approach relies heavily on intuition and varied interview styles, which contribute to inconsistent hiring decisions, higher turnover, and avoidable replacement costs.

The proposed system is built around a clear DSP Trainer competency model and includes:

- A structured behavioral interview with standardized questions and anchored rating scales.
- A situational judgment test (SJT) using realistic training and coaching scenarios.
- A teaching/coaching demonstration to observe real-time communication and group facilitation.
- A weighted scoring matrix that combines results from all tools into a single, transparent hiring decision.
- Realistic job preview and onboarding enhancements to set clear expectations and support early retention.

By using careful industry estimates for DSP turnover costs, even small increases in trainer retention can lead to big savings by lowering expenses related to recruiting, onboarding, and lost productivity. This structured, competency-based system positions Ascend to make more consistent, fair, and mission-aligned hiring decisions for one of its most critical roles.

Introduction



The Ascend Day Program offers essential services to adults with developmental disabilities, promoting independence, community engagement, emotional well-being, and daily living skills.

Since the Direct Support Professionals (DSP) trainer has a direct impact on the safety, learning, and behavior of clients, Ascend needs a clear and fair way to choose the right people for:

- Improves candidate quality
- Reduces turnover
- Ensures fairness and consistency
- Strengthens long-term retention
- Aligns hiring with Ascend's mission

These deliverables outline a comprehensive, multi-method selection process explicitly tailored to the DSP Trainer role.

Organizational Needs & Hiring Challenges

Table 1. Key Hiring Challenges

Challenge	Description
Inconsistent Interviews	Interviewers use varying questions, resulting in low reliability and bias.
No DSP-Specific Competency Assessment	Emotional regulation, coaching, and safety judgment are not systematically evaluated.
Misaligned Expectations	Candidates often underestimate emotional and documentation demands.
No Standardized Scoring	Without behavioral anchors, subjective, inconsistent decisions.
Low Retention (~20%)	Far below the Human Services benchmark (50–70%).

This selection system directly addresses each of these challenges.

Retention Impact & ROI Justification

High turnover in DSP roles creates significant financial strain for human-services organizations. Industry research estimates that each DSP turnover costs \$3,000–\$5,000 in recruiting, onboarding, training, lost productivity, and administrative time. Using a conservative estimate of \$4,000 per turnover, the impact is clear:

Table X. Financial Impact of Current vs. Improved Retention (per 5 hires)

Scenario	Employees Leaving	Estimated Cost
Current State (20% retention)	4	\$16,000
Improved State (50% retention)	2.5	\$10,000
Improved State (70% retention)	1.5	\$6,000

- Financial Savings
- At 50% retention: ~\$6,000 saved per 5 hires
 - At 70% retention: ~\$10,000 saved per 5 hires

- ROI Example
- (If Ascend invested \$2,000 in a selection system like this)
- 50% retention → 200% ROI
 - 70% retention → 400% ROI

Despite the free nature of this student consulting project, it showcases the financial benefits, scalability, and sustainability of a structured, competency-based hiring process.

DSP Trainer Competency Model

Competency	Description	Behavioral Indicators
Empathy & Emotional Regulation	Maintaining composure and providing support during emotional or behavioral episodes is crucial.	This involves active listening, de-escalation, and maintaining a stable presence.
Coaching & Instructional Skills	The instructional skills are imparted in a clear and effective manner.	Task breakdown, modeling, reinforcement.
Communication & Collaboration	Effective communication with clients, staff, and families is a crucial aspect of the job.	It involves maintaining a professional tone, fostering teamwork, and providing timely updates.
Organization & Documentation	Maintaining accurate records and managing tasks.	Prioritization, accuracy, and attention to detail.
Adaptability & Problem-Solving	Responding flexibly to unexpected needs or behaviors.	Calm decisions, creative solutions.
Safety Awareness & Judgment	The ability to identify risks and respond appropriately is crucial.	Protocol adherence, boundary setting, and hazard detection.

Complete Selection System Overview

This selection system includes five structured tools:

- 
- Structured Behavioral Interview
 - Situational Judgment Test (SJT)
 - Teaching/Coaching Demonstration
 - Weighted Scoring Matrix
 - Realistic Job Preview (RJP) + Onboarding Framework
- 

Each method evaluates different competencies, producing a comprehensive, predictive, and fair hiring process.

Structured Behavioral Interview Guide

Interview Structure

- 12 questions (2 per competency)
- Standardized 1–5 scoring scale
- Behavioral anchors
- Standardized probing questions
- Recommended two-interviewer format

A. Interview Questions by Competency

Empathy & Emotional Regulation

- Q1. Describe a situation where you provided support to someone during an emotional or behavioral challenge.
- Q2. Describe a moment you had to stay calm under pressure. What helped you regulate yourself?

Coaching & Instructional Skills

- Q3. Describe a time you taught someone a new skill. How did you break it down?
- Q4. Describe a situation where you adjusted your teaching approach to support someone who was struggling.

Communication & Collaboration

- Q5. Give an example of miscommunication or misunderstanding at work. How did you resolve it?
- Q6. Describe a time you had to communicate important information quickly and clearly.

Organization & Documentation

- Q7. Describe a time you managed multiple deadlines or tasks.
- Q8. Describe a situation where you were responsible for ensuring accurate documentation.

Adaptability & Problem-Solving

- Q9. Tell me about a time when something unexpected happened. What did you do?
- Q10. Describe a time you had to adjust to changing needs quickly.

Safety Awareness & Judgment

- Q11. Describe a time you identified a safety risk. What action did you take?
- Q12. Tell me about a time when you had to follow safety rules even when it was inconvenient.

Structured Behavioral Interview Guide

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B. Standardized Rating Scale

Table 3. Rating Scale (1–5)

SCORE	MEANING
1 - POOR	No relevant example; unsafe or inappropriate actions.
2 - BELOW AVERAGE	Limited skill or inconsistent behavior.
3 - AVERAGE	Basic competency: meets minimum requirements.
4 - ABOVE AVERAGE	Strong examples demonstrating solid competence.
5 - EXCELLENT	Highly detailed, exceptional example; exceeds job expectations.

Situational Judgment Test (SJT)

Scenario 1: Client Escalation

A client begins yelling and disrupting a group activity.

Best Response: C. Approach calmly, check triggers, de-escalate.

OPTION	SCORE
C	5
A	3
B	2
D	1

Scenario 2: Community Safety

A client wanders off in a store.

Best Response: B. Notify staff, locate client calmly, reinforce safety.

OPTION	SCORE
B	5
A	2
C	1
D	0

Scenario 3: Documentation Conflict

You realize that documentation is incomplete.

Best Response: C. Stay and complete it accurately.

OPTION	SCORE
C	5
B	2
D	1
A	0

Scenario 4: Client Refusing Activities

A client refuses an assigned task.

Best Response: B. Offer choices and adapt.

OPTION	SCORE
B	5
C	2
D	1
A	0

Teaching /Coaching Demonstration Rubric

Table 4. Teaching Demo Rubric

CRITERIA	1-POOR	3-AVERAGE	5-EXCELLENT
Clarity	Unclear Steps	Mostly	Simple, well-structured, step-by-step
Engagement	No Rapport	Some Engagement	Warm, patient, supportive
Adaptability	Rigid	Some Adjustment	Easily adapts to teaching
Pacing	Rushed or Disorganized	Adequate	Smooth and well-paced
Instructional Skill	No Modeling	Partial Modeling	Strong modeling with reinforcement

Weighted Scoring Matrix

Table 5. Final Score Composition

COMPONENT	WEIGHT
Structured Interview	50%
SJT	30%
Teaching Demo	10%
References	10%

Score Interpretation:

- 80–100: Highly qualified
- 60–79: Moderate fit
- Below 60: Not recommended

Realistic Job Preview (RJP)

“The DSP Trainer role requires patience, emotional stability, consistent documentation, and flexibility. You may support clients who are experiencing behavioral challenges or refusing to cooperate. A typical day includes teaching daily living skills, assisting with community activities, completing accurate records, and modeling positive behavior. The role is rewarding but can be emotionally demanding. We want you to fully understand these expectations to ensure the role aligns with your strengths.”

Onboarding Recommendations

Table 6. Onboarding Enhancements

Strategy	Purpose
Structured shadowing	Builds confidence through observation.
Weekly supervisor check-ins	Provides early support.
Mentor pairing	Reduces early turnover.
Micro-trainings	Improves documentation/safety skills.
Early performance conversations	Clarifies expectations.

Implementation Roadmap

Table 7. Rollout Plan

Week	Deliverables
1	Competency model + interview blueprint
2	Interview guide + SJT scenarios
3	Teaching demo rubric + scoring matrix
4	RJP script + onboarding improvements

Conclusion

This complete selection system provides Ascend with a fair, defensible, and predictive hiring model. Ascend will implement structured interviews, situational judgment tests (SJTs), teaching demonstrations, scoring matrices, realistic job previews (RJP) and onboarding improvements to enhance its hiring process:

- Improve hiring accuracy
- Increase retention
- Reduce turnover costs
- Strengthen safety and service quality
- Support staff success and development

The system is practical, scalable, and ready for immediate implementation.



Thank You

